Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A J 6 4
♥ 7 5
♦ 6 3
♣ A K 6 4 3

♠ 10 3
♥ K Q J 8 4
♦ 10 8 7 5
♣ J 8

♠ —
♥ 10 9 6 3
♦ K Q J 9 4
♣ Q 10 9 7

♠ K Q 9 8 7 5 2
♥ A 2
♦ A 2
♣ 5 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♠
Pass	2♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by South
Lead: ♥K

South is to play 6♠. West leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥5 and East the ♥3.

You win the ♥A and draw trumps with the ♠K and ♠Q.

West plays low.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 2

One of the two red losers must be discarded on dummy's ♣ suit. So you pull trumps, taking two rounds, with ♠K and ♠Q. Then play two top ♣s and ruff a ♣. When West shows out on the third ♣, enter dummy with a trump and ruff another ♣. Dummy's final ♣ is now established, so enter dummy with another trump and discard one of the red losers on the fifth ♣.

As long as the ♣s were no worse than 4-2 you can establish the suit.

Board 2
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 10 9 7 2 ♥ A J 6 ♦ 7 5 ♣ Q 6 4 3	
♠ K 6 4 3 ♥ 9 7 ♦ K 10 8 6 2 ♣ 8 2	N W E S	♠ A 8 ♥ Q 10 8 2 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ J 10 9 7
	♠ Q J 5 ♥ K 5 4 3 ♦ A 4 3 ♣ A K 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
All Pass			

1NT by South
Lead: ♦6

South is to play 1NT. West leads the ♦6, taken by East with the ♦J. East next plays the ♦Q on which West plays the ♦2. East plays the ♦9 which you finally win.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 6

You only need one more winner and you have several possibilities. The ♥ finesse might work, or the ♣s might split 3-3. But you need to consider the defenders winners also. They have already scored 2 ♦ tricks and will get 2 more as soon as they gain the lead. (The spot cards told you that West has a 5-card ♦ suit.) Plus they have the 2 top ♠s which they can take whenever they like. So if your play sets up just one more trick for them you will go down.

No, you must establish ♠s, the suit where they have 2 winners anyway. So you play a ♠ which West wins. He takes his 2 ♦s but you are now home free. When you gain the lead again you will get your ♠ winner established and only lose 2 ♠s and 4 ♦s.

If you finessed the ♥ you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♥ and 2 ♠s.

If you had played 3 rounds of ♣s you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♣ and 2 ♠s.

Only by establishing ♠s can you make the contract.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q 10 2 ♥ 8 6 ♦ 9 5 2 ♣ A 10 9 8 3	
♠ 9 8 6 5 3 ♥ Q 9 3 2 ♦ K 4 ♣ 6 2	N W E S	♠ A 4 ♥ J 10 4 ♦ Q J 10 6 ♣ J 7 5 4
	♠ K J 7 ♥ A K 7 5 ♦ A 8 7 3 ♣ K Q	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠9

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠9, taken by East with the ♠A. East next plays the ♠4.

You win with the ♠K and West plays low.

Everyone follows low.

West plays low.

East follows with the ♣5.

East wins with the ♣J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 8

You only need one more winner and if ♦s split 3-3 you can easily establish a trick in that suit. But what if ♦s split 4-2? If the ♣J falls you can get an extra ♣ trick. In fact, no matter how the ♣s are arranged you can establish your extra trick there.

First make sure that you win the second trick with the ♠K, keeping dummy's ♠Q for a later entry. Then play ♣K, and ♣Q overtaking with dummy's ♣A. Then play the ♣10, losing to the ♣J but establishing the ♣9 while you still have the ♠Q as an entry.

As you see, you couldn't set up a ♦ trick so the ♣ overtake was necessary to make the contract.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 8 5 2 ♥ Q 7 ♦ K 7 4 ♣ 8 6 4 3	
♠ Q 10 4 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ 9 3 2 ♣ K Q J 10		♠ K J 9 ♥ J 10 8 4 ♦ Q J 10 5 ♣ 9 2
	♠ 7 6 3 ♥ A K 5 2 ♦ A 8 6 ♣ A 7 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	2NT		
All Pass			

2NT by South
Lead: ♣K

South is to play 2NT. West leads the ♣K, dummy plays the ♣3 and East the ♣2.

West plays low.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=3 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 7

You need to find another winner and the chances are not good. If either black suit splits 3-3 you can establish dummy's fourth card in that suit. But with West's opening lead of the ♣K it is unlikely that ♣s will split. So your only slim hope is that the ♠s split 3-3 and dummy's fourth ♠ will be a winner.

Win the first trick and play a ♠ to the ♠A. Then play another ♠. The defense will win and probably take some ♣ tricks . When they have finished and play a red card, you win it and play a third round of ♠s. If both defenders follow to all three ♠s then dummy's ♠8 is now a winner.

This time you were lucky and the ♠s split evenly. Next time they probably won't and you'll go down.

Board 5
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 6 5 3 2 ♥ A K J 5 ♦ 6 5 ♣ 8 3	
♠ J 10 4 ♥ 8 3 ♦ Q 9 7 2 ♣ K Q J 10		♠ A K 9 7 ♥ 4 2 ♦ K 10 8 4 ♣ 9 6 5
	♠ Q ♥ Q 10 9 7 6 ♦ A J 3 ♣ A 7 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	3♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♣K

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♣K, dummy plays the ♣3 and East the ♣5.

East wins the ♠K.

East plays a trump, you follow low and West too.

Dummy leads a ♠ and East plays low.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 6

Obviously you don't really have 6 losers since some of those ♦s and ♣s can be ruffed in dummy. But if you are playing against competent defenders you will only be able to ruff two of them because every time they get the lead they will play a trump. So you must figure on ruffing 2 losers and establishing dummy's fifth ♠ for a discard of the other one.

Win the ♣A and immediately play your ♠Q. The defense will win this trick and probably play a trump. Be sure to win this in dummy and then ruff a ♠ with a high ♥. Now exit with a ♣. They will win and probably play another trump. Win this one in dummy also, breathing a sigh of relief when ♥s split 2-2. Ruff another ♠ with your second-last trump, then play ♦A and concede a ♦.

Whichever minor suit the defense plays next you ruff in dummy, then ruff the fourth ♠, establishing dummy's ♠8 while you still have a trump left in dummy. Dummy is now high.

It took a 2-2 trump split and a 4-3 ♠ split. But that was your best shot.

Board 6
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 7 5 ♥ K 8 7 5 3 ♦ A K 5 ♣ 10 2	
♠ J 9 6 3 ♥ J 2 ♦ Q J 10 7 6 ♣ 8 4	N W E S	♠ Q 10 4 ♥ Q 10 9 6 ♦ 9 3 2 ♣ 7 6 3
	♠ A K 2 ♥ A 4 ♦ 8 4 ♣ A K Q J 9 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♣
Pass	2♥	Pass	3♣
Pass	3NT	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♦[2]	Pass	5NT[3]
Pass	6♥[4]	Pass	7♣
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace
3. asks for kings
4. 2 kings

7♣ by South
Lead: ♦Q

South is to play 7♣. West leads the ♦Q.

East plays the ♦2 and you the ♦4.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=0 ♣=0 Total = 1

It should be very clear that the only way to get rid of that ♠ loser is to discard it on dummy's ♥ suit. So after taking the first trick with dummy's ♦A you could pull trumps, then play ♥A, ♥K and ruff a ♥. **IF** the ♥s split 3-3 you could then enter dummy with the ♦K and discard your loser.

The problem is that the ♥s are much more likely to split 4-2, in which case you will need to ruff twice to establish a winner. That means you will need an extra entry to dummy.

That extra entry can only be the ♣10 so you must delay pulling trumps until after you ruff the first ♥. Win the ♦A and immediately play ♥A, ♥K and ruff a ♥ with a high ♣. West discards on this ♥ play. Enter dummy with a trump and ruff another ♥ high. The suit is now established, so you pull trumps, enter dummy one last time with the ♦K and discard that losing ♠ on the good ♥8.

It may have seemed too risky to play ♥s before pulling trumps. In fact, there was no risk at all. If the ♥s were splitting 5-1 then you had absolutely no chance of making the contract.

And if they had split 3-3 this Plan would still have worked.